

INMO WESTERN BRANCH ANNUAL MIDWIFERY CONFERENCE

Saturday 20 March 2027

Radisson Blu Hotel, Lough Atalia Road, Galway

PRESENTATION SLIDES

Presenter: Joan Hampton, Community Midwife, University Hospital Galway

Session: 11.00 AM to 11.30 AM, Main Hall

Title: A Community Birth Centre for Galway: From Feasibility to the Road Ahead

SLIDE 1: TITLE

A Community Birth Centre for Galway

From Feasibility to the Road Ahead

Joan Hampton, Community Midwife, UHG

INMO Western Branch Conference, March 2027

SLIDE 2: WHY A BIRTH CENTRE FOR GALWAY?

3,400 to 3,700 births annually at UHG

28 to 35 percent are low-risk families who could safely choose a birth centre

The labour ward operates at or near capacity for significant periods each year

The national maternity strategy committed to birth centre access in 2016

Galway is the largest city in Ireland without a midwife-led unit

The question is not whether the evidence supports it. The question is why it has not happened yet.

SLIDE 3: WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Sandall et al. Cochrane Review 2024: 17,674 women across 15 RCTs

Preterm birth reduced: relative risk 0.76

Higher spontaneous vaginal birth rate

No increase in caesarean section or neonatal adverse outcomes

Higher maternal satisfaction consistently

Birthplace in England 2011: 64,000 women

Equivalent perinatal outcomes for low-risk women in midwifery units

Significantly fewer interventions: epidural, augmentation, instrumental birth

This is not a new model. It is a proven one.

SLIDE 4: WHAT WE PROPOSED

A standalone, freestanding midwife-led birth centre

350 to 450 families per year, low-risk, booked with a named community midwife
Formal transfer protocol to UHG, target under 15 minutes
Team of 6 to 8 whole-time equivalent community midwives
Integrated into the HSE West maternity network, not separate from it

SLIDE 5: THE FEASIBILITY WORK

Evidence review completed: October 2025 to January 2026
Three candidate sites assessed: Shantalla Road, Westside Road, and Salthill
Public consultation held: 10 October 2026, Galway City Hall
Consultation survey: 847 responses
Feasibility report submitted to Director of Midwifery: November 2026
Presentation to HSE West steering group: December 2026

SLIDE 6: WHAT WE HEARD AT CONSULTATION

847 survey responses. 89 percent in support or strong support.

"I drove to Dublin for my birth centre experience. I should not have had to."

"I wanted a home birth but was nervous. This would have been exactly what I needed."

"My midwife was the one person who knew me through the whole pregnancy. But she was not there for the birth."

"The labour ward is full. Something has to change."

SLIDE 7: WHERE WE ARE NOW

Formal service development proposal submitted to HSE West: February 2027
Site preference recommendation: Shantalla Road (HSE-owned building)
HSE West maternity services steering group decision expected: summer 2027
If approved in principle: planning application by end of 2027
Target opening: 2029

SLIDE 8: WHAT HAS NOT CHANGED

The evidence still says this is safe and effective.
The families still want it.
The midwives still want to provide it.
The labour ward still needs it.

None of that changed between 2016 and today. The difference now is that we have the data from 847 Galway families and a completed feasibility study.

SLIDE 9: WHAT YOU CAN DO

If you are a midwife in this region: document your clinical interest in birth centre work and let your manager know.

If you are involved in HSE workforce planning: the proposal includes a workforce case. Read it.

If you are a patient advocate: join the supporter list. The campaign is still active.

Contact: joan.hampton@Finthesiss.ai

SLIDE 10: REFERENCES AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Sandall, J. et al. (2024). Midwife-led continuity models. Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews.

Birthplace in England Collaborative Group (2011). BMJ, 343.

Department of Health (2016). Better Outcomes, Better Births. Government of Ireland.

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